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The Role of Personal Values in Marketing and Consumer Behavior

Can Personal Values be used to assist marketers in determining consumer choice behavior?

MARKETERS have long acknowledged the importance of attitudes and attitude change in the study of marketing and consumer behavior, but the role of values has received relatively little attention. Even though the marketing literature reflects an emerging interest in the topic,¹ personal values have not been widely used to investigate the underlying dimensions of consumer behavior. This is surprising considering the importance typically assigned to values by a wide variety of social observers and businessmen alike.²

While it seems that personal values have important implications for marketing practitioners and researchers, values and the ways in which they influence the behavior of consumers who look at and choose brands, product classes, and product attributes is not clear. In order to investigate these relationships, it is necessary to operationally define what values are, and to indicate empirical methods available for examining the connections between personal values and consumer behavior.

The purpose of this article is to address these issues. Specifically, attention will be focused on:

1. A discussion of the meaning of values and their relationship to behavior.

2. Presentation of an operational value paradigm suitable for studying consumer behavior.
3. Results of an empirical investigation of the impact of value orientations on the importance of product attributes, the appeal of various consumer products, and a number of social issues.
4. The implications of value analysis for the practice of marketing.

Personal Values

Conceptualization of the term "value" reflects the interest of several disciplines:

- ▶ Anthropology, with its interest in life styles and cultural patterns. (For example, Thomas and Zarniecki define values as "... objective, social elements which impose themselves upon the individual as a given and provoke his reaction.")³
- ▶ Sociology, focusing on ideologies and customs. (For example, Bronowski suggests that "a value is a concept which groups together some modes of behavior in our society.")⁴
- ▶ Psychology, which examines values from the standpoint of attitudes and personal motives. (For example, Rokeach views "... a value as a centrally held, enduring belief which guides actions and judgments across specific situations and beyond immediate goals to more ultimate end-states of existence.")⁵

In this article, and in the study reported herein, we follow mostly the psychological definition, and in particular Rokeach's view.

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Values & Behavior

The role of personal values as a standard or criterion for influencing evaluations or choices regarding persons, objects, and ideas suggest the relationship of values to behavior. Rokeach reports that "various combinations of values significantly differentiate men from women, hippies from non-hippies, hawks from doves, policemen from unemployed Negroes, good students from poor students, retail merchants from salesclerks, Jews from Catholics, Democrats from Republicans, and so forth."⁶ Williams has demonstrated that values relating to "cleanliness" have led to decisions concerning the choice of occupations,⁷ while England used personal values to investigate behavioral differences among corporate managers.⁸

Values, then, are responsible for the selection and maintenance of the ends or goals toward which human beings strive and, at the same time, regulate the methods and manner in which this striving takes place.

Values & Consumer Behavior

Other than a few isolated studies discussing changes in national values, research in marketing has been in the context of expectancy-value analysis based on the models of Rosenberg and Fishbein.⁹ Research interests have centered on predicting brand choice and assessing the relative importance of various product attributes in determining brand preference.

It is important to note that, with few exceptions,¹⁰ "value" as used in the context of expectancy-value research has been taken to mean product attributes and thus has a meaning different from that developed in this article. The expectancy-value approach has been useful in predicting brand choice but does not explain why consumers differentially evaluate product attributes and thus prefer one brand to another.

In order to gain insight into this question and to understand how changing national values influence consumption patterns, it would be useful, both for students of consumer behavior and for those marketing executives responsible for the formulation of marketing strategy, to have a framework integrating:

- Deep-rooted personal values
- Generalized consumption values
- Beliefs relating to product attributes

A Model of Consumers' Value Systems

A review of existing value literature, recent empirical research, and the cultural conditioning viewpoint on value acquisition leads us to propose that values may be investigated at three mutually dependent and at least partially consistent levels of abstraction. These levels, arranged in a hierarchical network, are referred to as global or generalized personal values, domain-specific values, and evaluations of product attributes. Exhibit 1 shows each level of values and suggest the influence of the socio-cultural, economic, and familial environment on the formation and development of the individual's value system.

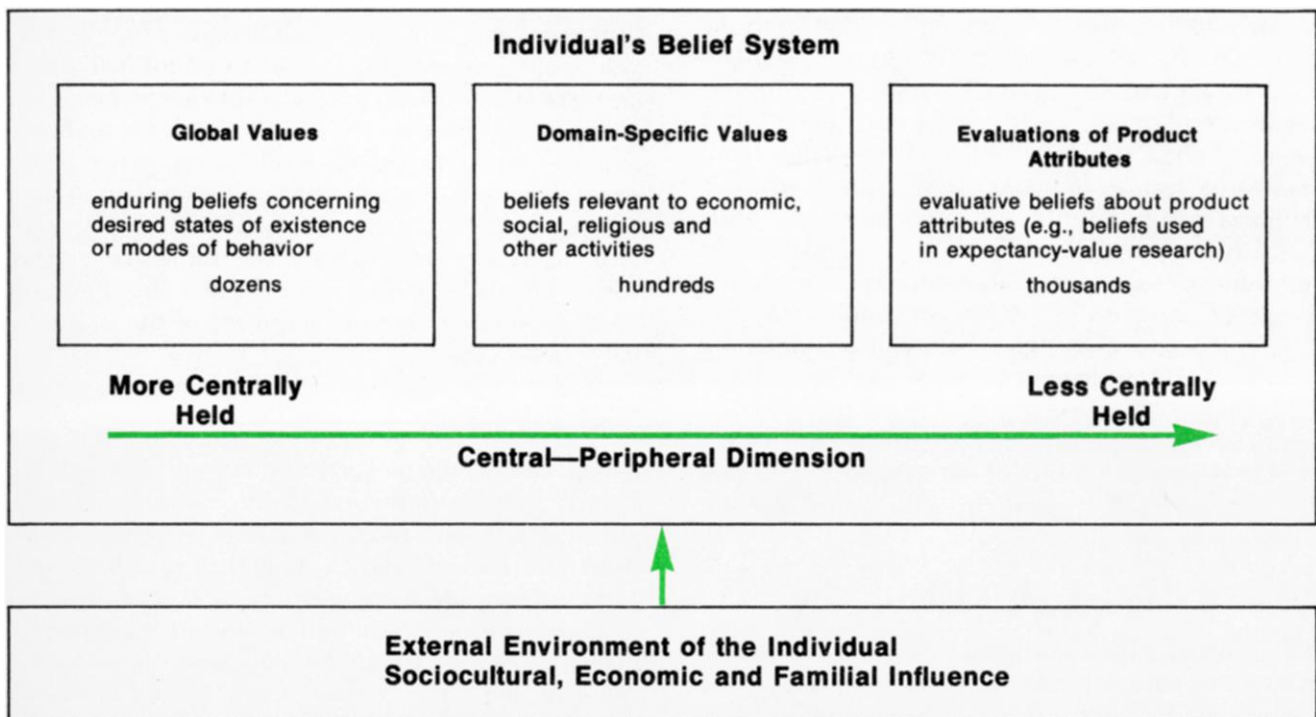
Global Values

Beliefs exist as the most elementary unit within this system. Very centrally held and enduring beliefs guide actions and judgments across specific situations and are referred to as global values. These global values are more abstract and generalizable than less centrally held beliefs. In our conception, these values form the central core of an individual's value system. They consist of closely held personal values which are of high salience in important evaluations and choices.

Domain-Specific Values

The second level of values, domain-specific values, reflects the belief that people acquire values through experiences in specific situations or domains of activity and that behavior cannot be understood or efficiently predicted except in the context of a specific environment. Thus, we contend that individuals arrive at values specific to economic transactions through economic exchange and consumption, at social values through familial and peer group interaction, at religious values through religious instruction and so on.

This intermediate value construct bridges the gap between the traditional conception of closely held, but very general, global values and the less closely held descriptive and evaluative beliefs about product attributes. Previous research has demonstrated this value construct to be cognitively separate but functionally related to an individual's system of global values and descriptive and evaluative beliefs.¹¹ A list of domain-specific values developed for consumption-related activities is shown in Exhibit 2.

EXHIBIT 1**Organization of the Consumer's Value-Attitude System**

This value set was developed from exploratory research with a large set of items and reduced through factor analysis. It includes statements about desirable modes of company behavior and desirable attributes of consumer products.

Evaluative Beliefs

The third category of values shown in Exhibit 1 is less abstract and consists of descriptive and evaluative beliefs. While such beliefs may be important, they are less centrally held. Among the many kinds of beliefs in this category are evaluative beliefs about the desirable attributes of product classes as well as specific brands. It is this category of values that most of the expectancy-value research has used in predicting brand appeal.

Note that the conceptual model shown in Exhibit 1 suggests that people have many thousands of evaluative beliefs, hundreds of domain-specific values, but only dozens of global values. Those beliefs and values do not exist as sharply separated and unconnected elements; they coexist in an interconnected hierarchical structure with the more durable and closely held global values exerting influence on each other as well as affecting the more peripherally located domain-specific values. These domain-specific values, in

turn, are inter-connected along the central-peripheral dimension and further influence the individual's evaluative beliefs associated with the attributes of products or brands.

Comparative Analysis of Values and Product Attributes

We have suggested that value acquisition represents a socio-cultural process and that differential value orientations will lead to variations in preferences for products and brands. To investigate these propositions, an exploratory research study was undertaken to investigate whether subjects from two culturally distinct regions of the United States would manifest different value orientations; and, if so, the extent to which these value differences may be related to attitudes toward automobiles and the importance of automobile attributes.

Additionally, measures were taken on attitudes toward a number of social issues to further explore attitudinal differences between the two groups. Information on related social issues such as air pollution and the energy problem can be of great importance in designing product and communications strategy for automobiles.

Subjects used in the research were selected from a sample of undergraduate marketing majors

EXHIBIT 2

Domain-Specific Values (Consumption-Related)

Manufacturers should . . .	Manufacturers & products should be . . .
provide prompt service on complaints	durable, long lasting
guarantee products to work as advertised	fairly, reasonably priced
be responsive to true needs of consumers	non-polluting
supply clear, accurate information on products	safe
help eliminate environmental pollution	inexpensive to use
care about the needs of individual consumers	exciting, stylish
repair defective products free of charge	easy to use
locate stores for convenience to consumers	dependable, trustworthy
not lie or be deceptive in advertisements	beautiful, attractive
make products available nights and weekends	in a wide variety
use courteous, helpful sales personnel	health-promoting
maintain the lowest prices possible	easy to repair
compete for the business of consumers	resistant to environmental damage
help solve urban decay and unemployment	quiet
work for legislation to protect consumers	comfortable, secure
not misrepresent a product	

at two large state universities. Group I subjects consisted of 47 students from a western university well known for the liberal attitudes and viewpoints of its student body and faculty. The 80 subjects comprising Group II were selected from a conservative southern university known for its more traditional approach to education. Data collected on demographic variables indicated that subjects were equivalently matched in terms of age, sex, and family income.

Each group was administered an identical questionnaire, which included a number of seven point Likert-type scales designed to measure the importance of the Rokeach global values and the consumption-related values presented in Exhibit 1. In addition, data were also collected on the importance of 20 automobile attributes, the appeal of 10 consumer products and services, and the importance of 15 current social issues.

Significant Differences

The results, summarized in Exhibit 3, indicate a large number of differences relative to the number of items. Items included under Group I subjects are those for which subjects in the group scored significantly higher than Group II subjects. Likewise,

the items shown with subjects in Group II are those for which these students scored significantly higher.

The differences between the two groups on values and attitudes toward social issues are striking and seem to identify two clear stereotypes. The first group seems to embrace more liberal, socially-motivated values and attitudes, while the second group seems more traditional or conservative in outlook. This confirms our prior hypotheses about these two groups. It should be noted, however, that we are describing the groups in a relative fashion, i.e., Group I relative to Group II. It may be possible to find other segments of the population who, in absolute terms, would score higher or lower than either group on any of the items.

It is particularly interesting to the marketer to examine how these two groups rated the importance of the automobile attributes and their appeal for classes of automobiles and other products. Specifically, the data suggest that the automobile attributes evaluated as important to each group are related to the type of automobile more preferable to that group, and several of the global and consumption values seem logically related to

EXHIBIT 3**Summary of Significant Differences Between Groups I and II****Group I Subjects**

Global Values	Domain-Specific Values	Automobile Attributes	Consumer Products	Social Issues
Exciting life ^a Equality Self-respect Forgiving Intellectual Logical ^a	Durable Products Non-polluting products ^a Health promoting products Products easy to repair Quiet products ^a Help eliminate environmental pollution	Operate on unleaded gas ^a High speed capabilities Handling Quality workmanship ^a Advanced engineering ^a Low level pollution emission ^a	Compact Cars ^a Outdoor Recreation ^a	Air pollution ^a Freedom of press ^a Control of housing discrimination ^a

Group II Subjects

National security ^a Salvation ^a Polite Social recognition	Prompt service on complaints	Smooth riding ^a Luxurious interior ^a Prestige ^a Large size Spacious interior ^a	Standard-size cars Stylish attractive clothing Television	Crime control The drug problem
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^a Significant at $p > .01$ level using "t" distribution. All others significant at $p < .05$ level.

the differentially evaluated automobile attributes and the appeal of various products or services:

- ▶ The more liberal Group I subjects had a higher preference for compact cars than standard size cars, which is consistent with their global and domain-specific economic values. They also indicated a higher preference for automobile attributes which enhance their desire for an exciting life, yet with non-polluting, durable products.
- ▶ On the other hand, the more traditional Group II subjects preferred larger, more prestigious standard-size cars, which is consistent with their values.

Implications for Marketing Management

While knowledge of personal values and changing value orientations has potential impact on all aspects of a marketing program, we believe some of the most promising avenues for research and application include market analysis and segmentation, product planning, promotional strategy, and public policy and society. Each of these application areas is discussed below.

Market Analysis and Segmentation

The research findings suggest that the basic value orientations of consumers can be expected to vary across geographical regions of the United States when various socio-cultural influences exist. Additionally, we might also expect the importance of personal values to vary by age, education, income, and other consumer demographics.

Knowledge of consumer value orientations provides an efficient, measurable set of variables closely related to needs which expand the marketer's knowledge beyond demographic and psychographic differences. If large market segments can be identified on the basis of value profiles, the marketing strategist could develop programs which would maximally enhance the important values of consumers in each market segment. Thus, in addition to the more traditional variables, values could be employed as a standard consideration in market analysis and as a tool to achieve greater precision and effectiveness in market segmentation.

Changing values in American society also have important implications for market analysis and segmentation. Business should be concerned with assessing changes in the size and composition of value segments and the implications of these changes for marketing. Here, professional market-

ing research organizations are useful in conducting broad based longitudinal research studies to identify changes in value orientations.¹² Marketing management would find this information of use in identifying new product opportunities and in modifying existing products to be consistent with consumer value profiles.

Product Planning

Careful assessment of value orientations and emerging value trends will allow the identification of new product opportunities and the repositioning of existing products. Changing importance of global values such as *pleasure, an exciting life, a comfortable life, and self respect* may very well signal the need for products having brand names, colors, and designs which enhance these important values in their use and consumption. A furniture manufacturer, for example, might connect this value change with an increasing demand for contemporary styled furniture and design a new line having bright, bold colors, unique materials of construction, and unusual comfort features.

The existence of value segments containing significant numbers of consumers suggests that products can be positioned by designing products with the attributes which are connected to the global values distinguishing that particular market segment. For example, a value segment containing consumers who regard the values *imaginative, an exciting life, and independent* as important might be defined as a market segment of consumers concerned with individuality and self expression. Manufacturers might find this a viable market for products which are partially finished (furniture, pottery, homes, etc.) as well as for products which can be tailored to the individual needs of consumers through the use of accessories, styling, chemical formulation, etc. Manufacturers and marketers of homes, automobiles, clothing, cosmetics, and fast foods have successfully pursued this strategy.

Promotional Strategy

Since global and consumption values appear to be connected to the importance of product attributes and the appeal of different product classes, this suggests that a promotional strategy designed to create and reinforce a preference by appealing to centrally held values may be highly effective. Thus, the promotional messages for a product or service could be developed to not only refer to the desirable attributes of the product but also to enhance these global and consumption values associated with the product attributes.

Additionally, the appeal to closely held personal values might have the effect of making consumers even more aware of an attribute of a product which previously may not have been considered salient or of which an awareness may not have existed. A department store, for example, knowing that the consumers in their target market held the consumption values, *care about the needs of individual consumers* and *prompt service on complaints*, and that these were in turn connected to the global values *polite* and *cheerful*, might initiate an advertising campaign emphasizing courteous, helpful personnel, and the store as a pleasant, cheerful place to shop.

Values should also be connected to media readership and viewing habits. By knowing the preferences of large market segments, the promotional strategist will be better able to select media and design appeals which will reach and enhance the important value of consumers. *Gourmet Magazine*, for example, might be associated with the values *polite, true friendship, and imaginative*. This magazine would then be useful as a medium to advertise products which enhanced these same consumer values, thus allowing the medium to reinforce the advertising message.

Public Policy and Society

Value research also has important implications for public policy. Consumers holding truth in advertising and honesty in representing products as important values in the economic system, for example, might react favorably toward federal regulation of marketing programs. By monitoring changes in the importance of these values, and other values dealing with the ethics of marketing, marketers can assess the mood of consumers and take action to correct undesirable aspects of their marketing programs before adverse consumer reaction makes it a necessity. Additionally, knowledge of the global values which are connected to these consumption values might be of interest to business firms planning corporate image and corrective advertising.

Conclusion

It has been suggested that values are centrally held cognitive elements which stimulate motivation for behavioral response. They exist in an interconnected, hierarchical structure in which global values are related and connected to generalized consumption-related values which are, in turn, similarly associated with product attributes. It has been generally accepted in consumer behavior research that these product attributes represent the

basic elements ordering an individual's attitude toward products and services. Hence, in our view, an individual's attributes are ultimately based upon his values, and changing values could have a profound impact upon these attitudes and upon behavior as well.

In order to test the proposition that values are culturally and socially learned, a study was conducted with subjects from two culturally distinct regions of the United States. The results indicated that the subjects were significantly different with respect to their basic value orientations and that

each of the three constructs representing the value-attitude system were logically structured. That is, global values, consumption-related values and the evaluation of product attributes were consistent with preference for the consumer products or services as well as for the perceived importance of the selected social issues.

Finally, while values have been shown to be theoretically important for studying consumer behavior, we have attempted to describe their relevance to the businessman engaged in marketing management activities.

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